

## Chapter 53\_1: Figure

Although Chu Qing Qiu's movements were somewhat stiff, they were indeed gentle. The crisp fragrance lingered at her nose, and Ning Fu Yi instinctively grabbed a tuft of Bai Lin's<sup>1</sup> fur.

Neither of them seemed quite accustomed to such gentle contact. Chu Qing Qiu quickly withdrew her hand into her sleeve and cleared her throat to hide her embarrassment, while Ning Fu Yi pulled out that tuft of fur and, realizing what she'd done, quickly threw it away.

Bai Lin, who was flying energetically, felt the irritation and raised a claw to scratch at his rear.

"Does Divine Venerable usually treat Qiu Yi<sup>2</sup> this way?" Ning Fu Yi turned her head to one side, not knowing why her heart had been beating faster just now.

"Not often." Chu Qing Qiu also looked toward the direction without Ning Fu Yi, concealing the unease in her voice.

"Oh." Ning Fu Yi nodded, having nothing more to say.

The atmosphere between them suddenly became extraordinarily strange, as if speaking wasn't right, but just sitting there wasn't right either.

As Ning Fu Yi was racking her brains for a topic of conversation, Chu Qing Qiu suddenly saw something and stood up, her voice becoming serious: "Bai Lin."

Hearing this, Bai Lin stopped his four legs that had been treading on clouds and floated quietly above them. Ning Fu Yi also stood up with her and looked down below, seeing mountain peaks standing in rows with clouds and mist swirling around them. A river like a green ribbon wound through the mountains.

There was nothing unusual, so she asked in confusion: "Divine Venerable?"

"Can you sense anything wrong?" Chu Qing Qiu stared at the mountains below and spoke.

Since Chu Qing Qiu asked this way, there must be something abnormal about the mountains below. Not wanting to be looked down upon, Ning Fu Yi closed her eyes and used her divine consciousness<sup>3</sup> to observe intensely. After seeing the scenery below clearly, a flash of lightning seemed to cross her mind.

"It's the season that's wrong. It's July in the mortal world, but many wintersweet blossoms are blooming in the mountains." She opened her eyes and said.

Chu Qing Qiu hummed in acknowledgment, then called Bai Lin again. Bai Lin quickly descended, transforming to normal size in mid-air as the two gracefully landed by the river.

The sound of rushing water filled their ears. A grove of wintersweet trees grew by the riverside, each blossom like carved jade. Snow-colored petals were blown into the river by the wind, tumbling in the waves as they flowed downstream.

Ning Fu Yi stood on her toes to pick a wintersweet blossom and smelled it, immediately shaking her head: "This isn't wintersweet. Although the shape is just like wintersweet, it doesn't have the fragrance that plum blossoms should have. Instead, it has a fishy, putrid smell."

"This is indeed not wintersweet." Chu Qing Qiu frowned deeply. Her slender fingers formed a flower-like gesture in front of her chest, then she spread her arms wide. A strong wind blew past, nearly uprooting those flowering trees.

The immortal wind stripped away the illusion from the plum blossoms, and soon those flowers revealed their true form—rootless, leafless flower stems inserted into the soil, with pitch-black petals pointing skyward, stiff and emanating faint black energy.

"Bone Beauties<sup>4</sup>?" Ning Fu Yi was shocked. These were the Bone Beauties that had masqueraded as Resurrection Lilies<sup>5</sup> in the underworld. She hadn't expected to see them in the mortal realm after they had left the underworld.

"I was wondering how an ordinary vengeful soul could transform into such a powerful fierce ghost, not only killing underworld judges but also summoning wind and rain to shroud the mountain village." Chu Qing Qiu shook her head and bent down to place her hand in the cool river water.

"The downstream of this river leads to Axe Head Village." Ning Fu Yi also said, knowing the seriousness of the situation. The appearance of demon clan flowers in both the underworld and mortal realm was definitely not a coincidence—someone was deliberately orchestrating this.

Someone wanted to see the world in chaos.

"We should return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate early. I must inform all the sects about this matter so they can be more vigilant and prepare early." Chu Qing Qiu spoke as she set fire to burn those Bone Beauties clean, then leaped onto Bai Lin's back.

They accelerated all the way and finally reached Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate at sunset.

Time in the underworld was different from the outside world—one day underground was many days in the outside world. Combined with the time spent in Axe Head Village, a full ten days had passed when they returned to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate remained the same as always, with days passing steadily and peacefully, except there were fewer disciples in the sect. Only half the people remained in Pearl Light Pavilion<sup>6</sup>. When Ning Fu Yi caught someone to ask, she learned that recently troubles had suddenly increased across the four seas and eight wastelands—if it wasn't demons causing havoc, it was ghosts running rampant. The disciples out subduing demons and eliminating evil were far from enough, so half the sect's people had been dispersed to various places to quell the disturbances.

This had exhausted Elder Yuan Ming<sup>7</sup>, who was in charge of training matters. It was said he was now running around outside daily, negotiating with other sects and aristocratic families. He hadn't been seen for ten days, and the other elders and managing disciples all looked haggard and utterly exhausted.

The first thing Ning Fu Yi did after returning to the sect was to look for Liu Wen Zhu<sup>8</sup>. However, after searching around and not finding her, she learned that she too had been sent out to quell disturbances. Fortunately, because her cultivation wasn't particularly high, she had been sent to the mortal realm to deal not with demons but with an emperor whose temperament had drastically changed and who had become debauched and tyrannical. Only then did Ning Fu Yi feel relieved.

Not to mention that place was also Liu family territory. Under the protection of the brave and skilled Liu family head, Liu Wen Zhu should be safe.

But these disturbances hadn't occurred in her previous life. Since her rebirth, the originally familiar world seemed to have had its core replaced—seemingly consistent everywhere, yet seemingly different everywhere.

When others were reborn, they defied fate and changed destiny, knowing all developments in advance. Her rebirth, however, was fate's unpredictability.

So in this life, besides herself changing, there must be others who were also different from the previous life. Only this could explain everything that had been secretly altered.

Besides this, she began to suspect the true reason for her rebirth. The Resurrection Lilies in the underworld indicated that she hadn't been reborn immediately after being stabbed to death by Chu Qing Qiu, but after passing through Naihe Bridge<sup>9</sup> and becoming a Resurrection Lily.

This proved that her rebirth might have been deliberately orchestrated by someone else.

But what was that person's purpose?

Ning Fu Yi couldn't figure it out. The only thing she could do was quickly improve her strength. She had never desired power so intensely. But unable to cultivate demonic arts, and with the difficulty of improving immortal power in the short term, plus the fact that she hadn't really cultivated immortal arts in her previous life, she began to consider finding someone to apprentice under and learn skills.

But after seriously considering many people, she felt none were suitable. The powerful people in the sect were nothing more than the sect master and elders. She didn't even want to look at that Mei Cheng Si<sup>10</sup> person, and the various elders were all busy running around every day.

So as she calculated this way, her thoughts landed on Chu Qing Qiu.

Previously, when Chu Qing Qiu had forcibly supervised her, she had sternly refused. Now going back would be somewhat embarrassing, but Ning Fu Yi couldn't care about so much. She thickened her skin and found some fruits and such to present to Chu Qing Qiu.

She had originally thought Chu Qing Qiu would scold her a bit, but unexpectedly, Chu Qing Qiu agreed without the slightest difficulty and even told her to come to Tranquil Mountain Palace<sup>11</sup> early the next morning.

So the next day, as soon as dawn broke, she crawled out of bed, tied her hair up high, and even specially changed into a plain silk dress. But after putting on the clothes, something felt wrong. Looking in the bronze mirror, she discovered that the hem that had originally dragged on the ground now hung at her calves.

She had been wearing the sect robes that Chu Qing Qiu made, which adjusted to fit her body, so she hadn't noticed. Now wearing ordinary clothes, she could see the problem.

She had actually grown so much taller without realizing it. Ning Fu Yi stared at herself in the bronze mirror and then reached up to touch her chest, unable to help raising an eyebrow.

Her originally flat figure had also grown dramatically. Under the outline of her dress, she could already see some resemblance to her adult form from her previous life.

Originally, because of her difficulty in cultivation, her figure was much smaller and thinner than her peers. When others were already adults, she was still a young girl.

In her previous life, she had grown up because of becoming a demon. Now it was presumably because of the immortal power that had suddenly filled her body. Ning Fu Yi reasoned thus, feeling delighted in her heart.

She then touched Ping An<sup>12</sup>, who was still sleeping, and walked lightly toward Tranquil Mountain Palace.

As she entered Tranquil Mountain Palace, the immortal attendant at the gate bowed and led her into the back garden. The back garden was even quieter than the front garden. In the midst of clusters of flowers, an open space had been cleared where Qiu Yi was already sitting cross-legged. She wore identical jade stone rings around her neck, waist, and wrists, frowning with eyes closed.

Hearing Ning Fu Yi's footsteps, she glanced at her with disdain, then closed her eyes again.

"You're here." Chu Qing Qiu's voice came from behind. Ning Fu Yi quickly turned around to see Chu Qing Qiu wearing white robes with red patterns, with a white gauze outer garment over them. Somewhat different from her usual coolness, it was eye-catching.

Crystal stones hung from her forehead, swaying with her movements.

"Stand over there." Chu Qing Qiu raised her wrist slightly, and Ning Fu Yi stood where she indicated. Then she felt coldness on her hands as a pair of jade stone rings identical to Qiu Yi's clasped around her wrists.

"What are these?"

"These are made from ancient divine jade and are extremely beneficial for improving cultivation." Chu Qing Qiu spoke while lifting her chin slightly. Ning Fu Yi's hands were forced upward. She quickly struggled, but her waist and neck were also clasped tight.

She immediately stiffened her body, having the illusion of being completely bound by Chu Qing Qiu, at her mercy.

Chu Qing Qiu stepped forward to arrange the hair that had been caught in the rings. Her warm hand brushed across Ning Fu Yi's neck, and Ning Fu Yi suddenly got goosebumps all over.

As Chu Qing Qiu was arranging her hair, confusion suddenly appeared in her refined eyebrows, and she said softly: "Did you grow taller?"

"Ah, yes." Ning Fu Yi didn't know how to explain and could only answer truthfully.

The young girl who had originally only reached Chu Qing Qiu's neck was now almost as tall as her. Chu Qing Qiu looked at her face—the childishness had somehow faded from that face, and her features had become more coldly sharp. When her lips were pressed together without smiling, it gave people a ghostly feeling.

When her phoenix eyes looked down at people, there was an aggressive sense of being watched.

Chu Qing Qiu's heart trembled, and her hand became somewhat unsteady holding the jade ring at Ning Fu Yi's neck. She quickly put her hand down nonchalantly and didn't look at her eyes again.

Seeing her not speaking, Ning Fu Yi thought she was shocked, so she added: "Besides growing taller, my body has also developed. Divine Venerable, look."

She straightened her waist a bit more. Chu Qing Qiu had no choice but to lower her gaze, and her eyes fell precisely on the area that symbolized her feminine identity. Her cheeks actually became hot, so she quickly turned around.

"I already know, no need to look." She said, "You practice your cultivation."

Ning Fu Yi was somewhat puzzled, but since she was teaching her to practice, she couldn't say much. So she nodded, closed her eyes, then opened them again.

"How do I practice?" she asked helplessly.

"The ancient divine jade will suppress your immortal power. You need to mobilize all your immortal power to resist it until you break free." Chu Qing Qiu instructed, then turned to leave the back garden. "I'll return in an hour."

But as soon as she took one step with her hands behind her back, she heard a great wind behind her and quickly turned back in shock, dodging several pieces of shattered jade flying toward her.

The young girl stood there looking sheepish, with empty space around her, innocently touching her nose.

"Divine Venerable, it broke."

## Footnotes:

1. **Bai Lin (白麟)**: Chu Qing Qiu's white qilin mount
2. **Qiu Yi (秋亦)**: Chu Qing Qiu's disciple
3. **Divine consciousness (神识)**: Spiritual awareness used by cultivators
4. **Bone Beauties (骨中娇)**: Demonic flowers from the demon realm
5. **Resurrection Lilies (彼岸花)**: Flowers that grow in the underworld
6. **Pearl Light Pavilion (珠光阁)**: A building within Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
7. **Elder Yuan Ming (元明长老)**: One of the elders at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
8. **Liu Wen Zhu (柳文竹)**: Ning Fu Yi's close friend
9. **Naihe Bridge (奈何桥)**: The bridge souls cross in the underworld before reincarnation
10. **Mei Cheng Si (梅承嗣)**: The sect master of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate
11. **Tranquil Mountain Palace (静山宫)**: Chu Qing Qiu's residence
12. **Ping An (平安)**: Ning Fu Yi's small white dog